The City Planners

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The City Planners

You will find a detailed guide to Margaret Atwood's poem 'The City Planners', from the Songs of Ourselves Volume 1, Part 4 anthology. It includes:

- **Overview**: a line-by-line "translation" of the poem, its possible meanings and interpretations
- **Writer's methods**: an exploration of Atwood's poetic choices and some potential effects
- **Understanding the text**: an exploration of Atwood's themes and ideas within her poem

Overview

In order to answer an essay question on any poem, it is vital that you understand what it is about. This section includes:

- The poem in a nutshell
- A "translation" of the poem, section-by-section
- A commentary of each of these sections, outlining Atwood's intention and message

'The City Planners' in a nutshell

'The City Planners' was written by the novelist, poet and environmentalist Margaret Atwood in 1964. The poem explores humanity's craving for uniformity and strict control over the environment and suggests that these desires are strange, suffocating and ineffective. Additionally, the poem critiques the exploitation of the earth's resources by what Atwood sees as **conniving** and selfish people called "city planners".

'The City Planners' breakdown

Lines 1–2

"Cruising these residential Sunday

streets in dry August sunlight:"

Translation

- The speaker begins by describing how they are "cruising" – walking calmly – through a street
- They also mention the day of the week, the month and also mention that they were travelling down a "residential"

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

- Atwood begins the poem by deliberately creating a calm and pleasant image:
  - It sets a vivid scene of suburban life on a tranquil Sunday in August
- The use of the word "cruising" suggests a leisurely pace, perhaps indicating the speaker's relaxed observation or exploration of the neighbourhood
- The mention of "residential Sunday streets" emphasises how quiet and **domestic** the surroundings are, suggesting that they are in an area with families rather than a busy inner-city street
- Sunday is also a significant day:
  - It is considered a day of worship and church for many
  - It is also a day of rest and relaxation
- The phrase "dry August sunlight" suggests comfort and calm as sunlight can be used to symbolise warmth and happiness

Lines 3–4

"What offends us is

the sanities:"

Translation

- The speaker is reflecting on what disturbs or bothers them about the suburban landscape they are observing:
  - The image that is created in the first two lines has changed now as we realise that the speaker and those with her are not enjoying themselves
- The phrase "what offends us" suggests a feeling of discomfort or disapproval, indicating that the speaker finds something troubling about their surroundings

Atwood's intentions

- Atwood creates a **juxtaposition** in these lines as the word "sanities" is used instead of insanities:
  - This word choice suggests that what unsettles the speaker is not chaos or disorder, but rather the very qualities that are usually associated with order, reason and rationality:
    - This creates a sense of **irony**
  - This could imply that the speaker sees the strict conformity and uniformity of the suburban environment as oppressive or stifling

Lines 5–12

"the houses in pedantic rows, the planted

sanitary trees, assert

levelness of surface like a rebuke

to the dent in our car door.

No shouting here, or

shatter of glass; nothing more abrupt

Translation

- The speaker provides a detailed description of the suburban landscape, focusing on the **meticulously** planned and perfectly manufactured nature of that environment
- The speaker begins by negatively describing the houses and then goes on to describe what they can see and hear in a way that highlights their displeasure

Atwood's intentions

- The phrase "the houses in pedantic rows" evokes an image of uniformity and precision, emphasising the rigid layout of the suburban neighbourhood:
  - This description highlights the lack of individuality in the architecture, suggesting a sense of **monotony** and conformity

- The mention of the "sanitary trees" further emphasises the artificiality of the environment, suggesting that even nature has been manipulated and controlled to fit the aesthetic:
  - The word "sanitary" carries connotations of cleanliness and orderliness, reinforcing the theme of sterilisation and uniformity

- The statement that these elements "assert levelness of surface like a rebuke to the dent in our car door" is particularly significant:
  - The speaker juxtaposes the flawless, orderly appearance of the suburban landscape with the imperfections and disruptions of everyday life, such as a dent in a car door
  - This contrast highlights the artificiality and superficiality of the suburban ideal, suggesting that it serves as a form of denial or repression of the messiness and chaos **inherent** in human existence

- The absence of "shouting" or the "shatter of glass" further emphasises the controlled, subdued atmosphere of the suburban neighbourhood:
  - Instead, the only sound is the "rational whine of a power mower", which serves as a symbol of the relentless maintenance and upkeep required to preserve the illusion of perfection in this environment
  - Atwood personifies that power mower and the use of the word "whine" implies that the sound is unpleasant and uncomfortable

- The description of the mower "cutting a straight swath in the discouraged grass" further underscores the sense of resignation and conformity that pervades the suburban landscape:
  - Again, Atwood uses personification and the use of the word "discouraged" highlights how even the natural world is subjected to human intervention and control

Help me understand

Lines 13–16

"But though the driveways neatly

sidestep hysteria

Translation

- In these lines, the speaker continues to critique the uniformity and monotony of suburban life, focusing specifically on the design and layout of the houses
- The speaker begins with the word "but", signalling that the viewpoint is about to change

Atwood's intentions

- The phrase "the driveways neatly sidestep hysteria" suggests that the neat, orderly arrangement of the driveways serves to avoid any sense of chaos or disorder:
  - This implies that the strict adherence to a uniform design in the suburban environment is seen as a way to maintain control and suppress any disruptions to the established order
  - The word "hysteria" here may connote a sense of irrationality or disorder, contrasting sharply with the calculated precision of the suburban landscape

- "The roofs all display the same slant of avoidance to the hot sky" implies a deliberate effort to turn away from the harsh reality of the natural world represented by the "hot sky":
  - This could be seen as a metaphor that represents the desire to protect oneself from the unpredictability of nature

Lines 17–22

"certain things:

the smell of spilt oil a faint

sickness lingering in the garages,

a splash of paint on brick surprising as a bruise,

a plastic hose poised in a vicious

coil; even the too-fixed stare of the wide windows"

Translation

- In these lines, the speaker provides a more **nuanced** view of the suburban environment by highlighting the subtle signs of decay and disorder among the orderliness
- These lines suggest that there may be something hidden beneath the perfect façade and that not everything is as ordered and curated as it initially seemed

Atwood's intentions

- The reference to the "smell of spilt oil" and the "faint sickness lingering" suggests that there may be some pollution or contamination that disrupts and distorts the perfect image of the suburban landscape:
  - These details can serve as a reminder of the imperfections and impurities that exist beneath the surface, which undermine the façade of cleanliness and control

- The description of the "splash of paint" resembling "a bruise" further emphasises the intrusion of imperfection

- The image of a "plastic hose poised in a vicious coil" creates a sense of danger or a threat within an environment that is normally considered safe:
    - The word "vicious" conveys a sense of aggression or hostility suggesting that the instability and unpredictability of nature has been replaced with a man-made danger
    - This is ironic as the desire to control and overpower nature has resulted in problems and perils that are human constructs

- The personification of the "too-fixed stare of the wide windows" suggests a sense of surveillance or scrutiny, as if they are watching and are fixated on a particular objective

Lines 23–25

"give momentary access to

the landscape behind or under

the future cracks in the plaster"

Translation

- The first line is a continuation of the last line from the previous stanza
- The speaker is describing how the windows give access to what is going on beneath the surface and suggests a fleeting glimpse beneath the surface of the carefully constructed suburban environment
- It suggests that the speaker is able to see beyond the exterior of the manicured environment and is able to see the cracks and deterioration beneath it
- The speaker knows that the man-made constructs will not last and that they are temporary

Atwood's intentions

- The phrase "give momentary access to the landscape behind or under" implies that the speaker is able to glimpse fleetingly beneath the façade:
    - This could be interpreted as a metaphor for the hidden realities and uncertainties that lie beneath the illusion of order and control

- By mentioning "the future cracks in the plaster" the speaker is alluding to the eventual deterioration of the suburban infrastructure, hinting that cracks and flaws will begin to appear:
    - This serves as a reminder of the temporary nature of human constructions and highlights the futility of trying to impose permanence on a world that is constantly changing

Lines 26–28

"when the houses, capsized, will slide

obliquely into the clay seas, gradual as glaciers

that right now nobody notices."

Translation

Atwood's intentions

- The use of vivid imagery conveys a sense of impending change and decay within the suburban landscape
- Atwood paints a striking picture of the houses sinking or collapsing into the "clay seas" to emphasise the vulnerability and impermanence of human constructions:
  - The use of the word "capsized" evokes metaphorical images of ships overturned and sinking, suggesting a sense of disaster or upheaval

- The comparisons to "glaciers" further emphasises the gradual nature of the process, which is so slow that it is not noticeable to people:
  - However, the use of the modal verb "will" suggests that the houses and suburban life are temporary and not built to last forever

- The phrase "right now nobody notices" suggests a sense of obliviousness or indifference on the part of the inhabitants, despite the signs of decay and instability that the speaker had described in previous stanzas:
  - This serves to underscore the theme of human folly and **hubris**, highlighting the disconnect between the control and stability that human beings think they have and the harsh realities of the natural world

- These lines serve to challenge the notion of permanence and security that underpins the suburban landscape and highlights the fragile nature of human existence in the face of natural forces

Lines 29–33

"That is where 'The City Planners'

with the insane faces of political conspirators

are scattered over unsurveyed

territories, concealed from each other,

each in his own private blizzard;"

Translation

- In this stanza, the titular "City Planners" are mentioned:
  - They symbolise urbanisation and are responsible for planning and shaping the urban environments

- The speaker presents a vivid and unsettling portrayal of these individuals by describing them as "scattered" and isolated from one another

Atwood's intentions

- By comparing the City Planners' faces to those of political conspirators, Atwood suggests a sense of secrecy, manipulation and hidden agendas:
  - The use of the word "insane" further emphasises the unsettling nature of these individuals, implying a disregard for sanity in their pursuit of power and control

    motivations are described as "insane"
- The image of the Planners "scattered over unsurveyed territories" evokes a sense of chaos and disorder within the urban landscape:
    - The mention of unsurveyed territories suggests areas that they have not properly planned or assessed areas that they are building on
    - This is ironic as their name implies organisation, forethought and careful planning in teams, which, the speaker implies, they do not do

- The phrase "concealed from each other, each in his own private blizzard" further emphasises the disconnect and isolation among the City Planners:
    - Despite their collective responsibility for shaping the urban landscape, they remain isolated from one another, trapped within their own private worlds of delusion and obsession
    - The metaphor of the blizzard suggests a sense of confusion and disorientation, highlighting the chaotic and overwhelming element of their own individual pursuits

- These lines serve to critique the arrogance and folly of those who seek to control and manipulate the environment:
    - Atwood's evocative imagery and language invite the reader to contemplate the danger of unchecked power and hubris, urging them to confront the illusions of control that underpin modern society

Lines 34–36

"guessing directions, they sketch

transitory lines rigid as wooden borders

on a wall in the white vanishing air"

Translation

- In these lines, the speaker continues to depict the actions of the City Planners in shaping the urban landscape, highlighting the impermanence of their efforts

Atwood's intentions

- The phrase "guessing directions" suggests a lack of certainty or precision in the City Planners' actions as they seem to be guided by guesswork or **intuition** rather than careful planning and analysis:
    - This highlights the **arbitrary** nature of urban planning and the potential consequences of decisions made without full understanding

- Atwood uses a simile to describe how the City Planners are sketching "transitory lines rigid as wooden borders", which implies that these lines are impermanent and fleeting:
    - Despite these lines initially appearing as "rigid", they are ultimately insubstantial and temporary

- The use of the phrase "white vanishing air" further emphasises the intangible nature of these boundaries,

against nature, such as describing "transitory lines" as "rigid":
    - Atwood critiques and mocks the folly of humanity's attempts to control and manipulate the environment
    - These lines encourage the reader to reflect on the limitations of human knowledge and understanding by highlighting the arrogance and ignorance of those who seek to impose order and control upon the natural world

Lines 37–38

"tracing the panic of suburb

order in a bland madness of snows."

Translation

- The poem concludes the criticism of the City Planners and the absurdity of their planned order

Atwood's intentions

- The phrase "tracing the panic of suburb" suggests that there is a sense of anxiety or unease lurking beneath the surface of the suburban environment:
    - There is a sense of underlying chaos that the City Planners are attempting to suppress and conceal
- The use of the word "tracing" suggests that the cycle has started again and that the City Planners are building a new suburb that is the replica of previous suburbs
- Atwood juxtaposes "panic" and "order" to highlight how the stability and security that underpins suburban life is an illusion
- The description of this panic as existing "in a bland madness of snows" adds to the sense of surrealism:
    - The contrast of the blandness of the suburban landscape with the madness of the panic highlights the ways in which the suburban ideal can be both oppressive and absurd
    - The imagery of "snows" suggests a sense of coldness and emptiness beneath the surface
- It is worth noting that, for the final half of the poem, Atwood uses natural forces such as "glaciers", "blizzard", "white vanishing air" and "madness of snows" to metaphorically immerse the City Planners and surround them with the natural elements:
    - This makes them appear small and their efforts appear futile
    - As a result, the reader is able to understand the absurdity of their project and how they are ultimately powerless with their efforts eventually disintegrating and fading away

Examiner Tips and Tricks

question and summarising what the poem tells us about that particular theme. This demonstrates that you have understood the poem and the poet's intention.

For example: "Atwood presents the negative impact of hubris and its effects in 'The City Planners' by suggesting that no matter how perfect suburban life may appear, it will eventually succumb to decay and disintegration."

Writer's Methods

Although this section is organised into three separate sections – form, structure and language – it is always best to move from **what** the poet is presenting (the techniques they use; the overall form of the poem; what comes at the beginning, middle and end of a poem) to **how** and **why** they have made the choices they have.

Focusing on the poet's overarching ideas, rather than individual poetic techniques, will gain you far more marks. Crucially, in the below sections, all analysis is arranged by theme, and includes Atwood's intentions behind her choices in terms of:

- Form
- Structure
- Language

Examiner Tips and Tricks

The last thing examiners want to see is what they call "technique spotting". This is when students use overly sophisticated terminology unnecessarily, and sometimes inaccurately, without any analysis of how the technique in question contributes to the overall effect of the poem or deepens our understanding.

Knowing the names of sophisticated literary techniques will not gain you any more marks, especially if these techniques are only "spotted" and the poet's intentions for this language are not explained. Instead of technique spotting, focus your analysis on the reasons **why** the poet is presenting their ideas in the way that they are: what is their message? What ideas are they presenting, or challenging?

Form

The poem is written in seven stanzas that are separated into uneven sets of lines. It is a **free verse** poem and so it does not follow any specific pattern of metre or rhyme.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention

	does not follow any regular pattern. The line lengths and rhythms vary within each stanza	is, which contrasts with the stifling and rigid order of the residential area with its "planted sanitary tree" and "the houses in pedantic rows"

Structure

The lines in the poem are broken into varying lengths, with the first stanza containing the most lines and the last stanza containing the fewest.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Nature versus civilisation	The poem consists of seven stanzas of varying lengths, ranging from twelve lines at the beginning to two lines at the end	The irregular structure reflects the chaotic and disjointed nature of the suburban environment that the poem critiques and how, eventually, they will **disintegrate** and will become a part of the "clay seas"
Hubris and arrogance	The poem is divided into distinct sections, each focusing on different aspects of the suburban landscape and the actions of the City Planners, with the final stanzas focusing on the City Planners and their efforts	The structure of the poem could be seen to imitate the melting of glaciers and serve as a warning that, despite the arrogance and confidence of humankind, their buildings and desire for order will ultimately disintegrate. Atwood may have chosen this structure to question the arrogance and hubris of those who seek to impose their will upon the natural world

Language

Atwood uses a range of literary devices in the poem to highlight humanity's futile efforts at maintaining order in a world they do not understand.

Theme	Evidence	Poet's intention
Nature versus civilisation	The poem uses enjambment frequently,	Atwood uses punctuation in stanzas one and at

	punctuation. This is evident at the end of stanza two, which links to the beginning of stanza three	nature of the suburban, residential areas However, she then uses enjambment, which could reflect the fluid and uncontrollable force of nature. Man-made order and control has been replaced by the end of the poem
Decay and disintegration	The poem uses imagery to highlight the decay and disintegration of suburban areas. For example, in stanza two, the "sickness lingering", the "bruise" and the "cracks" in the plaster	Atwood hints at the impermanence and decay that underlies the suburban landscape and suggests that the carefully constructed façade of suburban order is ultimately unsustainable and destined to disintegrate and fade away

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Try not to separate "language", "form" and "structure" into three separate elements you need to include in your answer. To achieve top marks, you need to include an **integrated** exploration of the themes and ideas in your chosen anthology poem, and focus on the relevance of the method used by the poet to the ideas in the poem.

This means it is better to structure your answer around an exploration of the ideas and themes in the poem, based on the focus of the question, commenting on elements of language, form or structure that contribute to the presentation of these themes, rather than simply listing all of the key methods you think should be covered when writing about poetry (with no analysis or exploration of their relevance to the themes and ideas). Stay focused on the task, and then choose your comments based on the focus of the question.

Understanding the text

understanding of the themes, main ideas, settings, situations and events depicted. While context is not explicitly assessed in the IGCSE, an awareness of background information as relevant to the main themes in the poem can help you to develop a sustained, critical understanding of the text, so that you are able to demonstrate individuality and insight in your answer. Therefore, this section has been divided into two main themes that Atwood explores in 'The City Planners':

- Nature versus civilisation
- Hubris and arrogance

Examiner Tips and Tricks

It is very important that you don't just write factual information about Margaret Atwood or historical, contextual information that is unrelated to the ideas in 'The City Planners' and the focus of the question. You are being asked to explore the text beyond surface meanings to show deeper awareness of ideas and attitudes, so while having some background information is essential for this, be sure to always link these things to the themes in the poem as relevant to the focus of the question.

Nature versus civilisation

- Margaret Atwood's father was an entomologist (a scientist who studies insects) which gave Atwood a deep appreciation for nature
- 'The City Planners' was in response to the increase in suburban neighbourhoods throughout the mid-20th century:
  - In the aftermath of World War II, Canada and the United States saw an increase in demands for houses
  - To meet the demands, houses were built fast, using cheap materials to mass build houses with the same design and layout
- The poem **alludes** to the uniformity and standardisation of the houses by describing them as being in "pedantic rows" and referencing how even nature is controlled with the "planted sanitary trees"
- Atwood critiques these buildings and projects by suggesting that the man-made structures are fragile and not planned thoroughly enough to withstand nature's force:
  - She implies that they will "slide obliquely into the clay seas" as, beneath the façade, it is evident that there are "cracks"
- At the end of the poem, Atwood uses snow and ice as the **motifs** to emphasise the power of nature and how the City Planners are isolated and engulfed in "his own private blizzard", reemphasising the idea that civilisation cannot overpower nature

divided, but they are trying to build on land that they know nothing about:
    - Their sketched "transitory lines" fade and vanish, which suggests that Atwood feels that their efforts are futile and their plans impermanent

Hubris and arrogance

In 'The City Planners', Atwood portrays the theme of hubris and arrogance primarily through her depiction of the City Planners and their actions

- She describes them as having "insane faces of political conspirators":
    - This characterisation immediately suggests a sense of irrationality and secrecy surrounding their actions
    - The use of the word "conspirators" suggests that the City Planners have ulterior motives and are willing to manipulate and deceive in pursuit of their goals
- Atwood describes them as being "scattered over unsurveyed territories, concealed from each other" which suggests a lack of oversight and accountability in their planning process:
    - The idea that they are concealed from each other implies a lack of transparency and collaboration, which further highlights their arrogance in believing that they alone hold knowledge and authority
- The poem suggests that the City Planners make decisions based on guesswork rather than careful consideration and prior research:
    - The phrase "guessing directions" indicates that their actions are driven by whims or personal preferences rather than research or evidence
    - By treating the landscape as a blank canvas, the City Planners demonstrate their arrogance in assuming they can mould it according to their desires
- Ultimately, the poem suggests that their hubris and arrogance will lead to the downfall and disintegration of these suburban landscapes as they are founded on greed and a desire for control

Examiner Tips and Tricks

For further advice and guidance on how to answer the poetry question, please see our detailed revision guides on Paper 1 Section A, which include "What the Question is Asking", "How to Get Full Marks" and a full, annotated model answer. It is important to remember that no marks are given for any comments you might make in your answer to any of the other poems studied in the anthology. Your response should concentrate only on the poem and the focus of the question.

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